STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE			PS-4100	
	SARPY COUNTY SHERIFF'S OFFICE PAPILLION * NEBRASKA **GREG LONDON** **SHERIFF**	DATE ISSUED 06/06/23	DATE REVISED **02/20/25**	DATE REVIEWED 02/02/25
		APPROVED: *GREG LONDON*		
CHAPTER TITLE **PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS**		RESOURCES		
SUBJECT CHAPLAIN PROGRAM		CROSS REFERENCE G-4300 SHERIFF'S OFFICE VEHICLES G-4310 CRASHES INVOLVING COUNTY VEHICLES P-5400 RIDE ALONG PROGRAM		

I. Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to establish the procedures for the chaplain program.

II. Policy:

The Sarpy County Sheriff's Office in conjunction with other local agencies maintains a chaplain program. Chaplains are available for a variety of incidents and to provide counseling, guidance, and support to citizens of Sarpy County and employees of the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office as well as police departments within Sarpy County. Chaplains are not paid employees but function under the policies of the Sheriff's Office when functioning as a Chaplain for the Sheriff's Office.

III. Procedures:

A. Chain of Command: The Sheriff ultimately defines the duties and responsibilities of the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office Chaplains. The chaplains shall also have an established chain of command as follows:

1. All chaplains shall be under the direct command of the Assistant Professional Standards Commander/CALEA Administration Manager.

2. The chaplains, at the direction of the Assistant Professional Standards Commander/CALEA Administration Manager, shall appoint a Lead Chaplain. The Lead Chaplain shall function as the liaison between the Sheriff's Office and the chaplains and generally is a senior chaplain.

3. When a chaplain is called into "duty," he or she shall be under the supervision and direction of the on-duty supervisor or command officer who requested the chaplain or who is in command of the incident.

4. The Chaplain program may organize itself with additional officers and committees as need to carry out its purpose.

B. **Chaplain Qualifications:** The Lead Chaplain and the Assistant Professional Standards Commander/CALEA Accreditation Manager shall review all applications for the position of chaplain and shall then make a recommendation to the Sheriff on whether to accept or reject the applicant. The decision to appoint a chaplain is the sole responsibility of the Sheriff.

1. Chaplains must be ecclesiastically ordained or possess relevant theological preparation **AND**

2. Have two years of ministry or equivalent experience.

C. **Chaplin Responsibilities/Duties:** Chaplains are available to assist Sarpy County Sheriff's Office employees in the performance of their duties. The areas where chaplains may assist include but are not limited to the following areas:

1. Family Crisis Intervention: Provides counseling to individuals involved in incidents where they are friends or family members of victims of homicides, suicides, traffic or other accidental deaths, and natural deaths. Comforts families involved in serious injury incidents or serious crimes. Provides counseling or referrals to families involved in chronic domestic abuse situations.

2. Death Notification: Assists deputies in contacting family members regarding the death of a relative.

3. Non-Emergency Transportation: Chaplains are available for the transportation of adults and/or children to safe shelter in cases of domestic violence or during incidents not requiring emergency assistance.

4. Suicide or Suicide attempt: Chaplains are available to work with persons suffering from depression or the families of individuals who have committed or attempted to commit suicide.

5. Domestic Violence: Chaplains are available to assist in counseling and locating safe shelter for victims of domestic violence.

6. Crisis Response: Chaplains are available for counseling employees of a business victimized by robbery or an employee death or students dealing with the sudden death of a classmate. Chaplains are available to assist families involved in the damage or destruction of their home due to severe weather or fire. May respond to mass casualty incidents to aid survivors and families.

7. Resources and General Assistance: Chaplains may assist persons who are stranded, confused or emotionally distraught.

8. Individual Counseling: Chaplains are available to Sheriff Office employees and their families for personal relationship issues.

9. Critical Incident Stress Debriefing (CISD): Chaplains may assist members of the Sheriff's Office who have responded to critical incidents, by being a member of CISD Team.

D. **Restrictions and Responsibilities:** Chaplains are not law enforcement officers and shall not assume such a role, but as a representative of the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office, chaplains shall function under the following restrictions and shall fulfill the following responsibilities:

1. Chaplains are authorized to visit Sheriff's Office facilities and incident scenes where activities indicate the need for ministerial services but shall at no time interfere with Sheriff's Office operations.

2. Chaplains may converse with employees when the need for ministerial service is requested or apparent, provided such communication does not interfere with department operations.

3. During field operations, chaplains shall comply with orders and instructions of sworn personnel in charge of the incident.

4. If a Chaplain desires to do a ride along, he or she shall contact the supervisor of that shift and request permission. Chaplains should attempt to contact the shift supervisor for permission twenty-four (24) hours prior to the desired ride along time. If permission is granted, the Chaplain shall arrive fifteen minutes (15) prior to the start of the shift or agreed upon ride time. Chaplains shall ride with the prearranged deputy no more than four (4) hours per duty shift unless other arrangements have been made and approved by the appropriate Watch Commander. If a Chaplain desires to go on a particular assignment with a deputy, the chaplain must have permission and be authorized by the appropriate supervisor.

5. All information communicated to the chaplain while acting in the role of a religious officer will be recognized as privileged communications.

6. Chaplains shall not release any information to any source (e.g., news media, insurance agencies, attorneys, etc.) regarding agency activities or investigations without first obtaining consent from the Sheriff.

7. Chaplains are subject to all appropriate agency rules and regulations, and any breach or violation of such may be grounds for suspension or dismissal.

8. Chaplains are to be always professional and abide by the Standards of Conduct required of all employees of the Sheriff's Office (see G-1200) and the Code of Ethics for Chaplains (see section I below).

9. While at an incident, chaplains shall refrain from drinking alcoholic beverages or ingesting any non-prescribed drug. Chaplains taking prescription medication shall inform the Assistant Professional Standards Commander/CALEA Accreditation Manager of any potential concerns.

E. **"On-Call" and Request Procedures:** The chaplains shall function under the following procedures:

1. The Lead Chaplain shall establish an "on-call" rotation for a three-month period. The Sarpy County Communications Center shall be furnished with a copy of the current "on-call" rotation by the Lead Chaplain.

2. The change in "on-call" chaplains shall take place at 0800 hours on Friday of each week. It is the responsibility of the Chaplain coming "off-call" to have the Chaplains car at the LEC by 0800 hours unless other arrangements have been made with the Chaplain starting his or her "on-call" shift. Upon receiving the Chaplain's car from the previous "on-call" chaplain, the chaplain shall notify the Sarpy County Communications Center they are now assuming the "on-call" Chaplain duties.

3. Any chaplain who has a schedule conflict or for some reason is not available for all or part of his or her scheduled "on-call" week shall be responsible for securing another chaplain to cover for that time.

4. If a supervisor or command officer requests a chaplain, he or she may contact Communications to have the "on-call" chaplain paged or may contact the chaplain directly by phone.

5. Chaplains shall only be called to the scene of an incident when the situation has been stabilized or where the chaplain will be staged at a safe location.

6. Chaplains are to keep a log of activity and turn the log into the Lead Chaplain upon the end of his or her "on-call" period. Chaplains shall forward their activity to the Professional Standards Commander and Assistant Professional Standards Commander including report number, time of call out, time in service, address, and requesting agency. This shall be done by email or text message.

7. Chaplains shall notify the Professional Standards Commander and Assistant Professional Standards Commander whenever his or her actions affect the outcome of the incident; or he or she has information that would be relevant to an on-going investigation or prosecution.

F. **Attire:** While functioning in an official capacity, chaplains shall be clean and properly attired. Chaplains shall adhere to the following procedures regarding attire:

1. Chaplains may wear attire or a symbol of faith that clearly identifies them as a member of the religious community.

2. Each Chaplain shall be issued a Chaplain's badge and staff identification. Chaplains shall wear this identification when inside Sheriff's Office Facilities.

3. Attire shall include a Sheriff's Office jacket with front panel displaying the words, "Sheriff Chaplain" above a Sheriff star, a back panel displaying the words "Sheriff Chaplain". During warm weather months, Chaplains shall wear a Sheriff's Office polo with the same insignia.

G. **Radio Procedures:** The "on-call" Chaplain shall be assigned a portable radio and will adhere to the following procedures:

1. Each Chaplain shall be assigned a specific radio call sign. The designated call signs for chaplains are Chaplain 1, Chaplain 2, etc. The "on-call" chaplain shall use the radio call sign that has been assigned to him or her when responding in service.

2. Chaplains shall use LE-SHERIFF-S when responding to SCSO, LE-WEST-S for LVPD and PPD, and LE-EAST-S for BDP. In the event of an incident with multiple Chaplains in service, Communications may assign the Chaplains to a different talk group.

3. Contacting Communications: When contacting Communications, chaplains shall use the following procedure:

   a) Chaplains shall advise their radio call sign (e.g., Chaplain 1).
   b) Chaplains shall wait for dispatch to repeat the call sign.
   c) Chaplains shall again state their call sign and provide the appropriate information (e.g., Chaplain 1, in service).
   d) Chaplains shall call in service using this procedure

H. **Sheriff's Office Vehicle:** The Sheriff's Office shall maintain a Chaplain vehicle. The vehicle shall be identified by Sarpy County Sheriff's Office markings with the word "Chaplain" clearly visible. The vehicle shall not be used for personal use. Chaplains shall adhere to all Sheriff's Office procedures regarding the use of the

Chaplain vehicle (see G-4300 Sheriff's Office Vehicles and G-4310 Accidents Involving County Vehicles).

1. Any auxiliary lighting on a Chaplain vehicle shall only be used once the chaplain is on scene, the vehicle is parked, and it is necessary for safety. Chaplains are not trained in emergency vehicle operations and shall not use auxiliary lighting in the capacity that first responders use them.

I. **Code of Ethics for Chaplains:** The Chaplain Corps desires to maintain the highest possible standard of professional ethics, recognizing that all people have intrinsic value. The Chaplains recognize that the goal of pastoral care is to enable people to use their own ethical-religious system of beliefs and values to find meaning and purpose in life. In recognition of this responsibility, each member of the Chaplain Corps shall strive to practice in accordance with this code of ethics.

1. Ideals: Members of the Chaplain Corps shall exhibit professional expertise with the dignity of the office of clergy, recognizing that above all, they are servants. Members are expected to give unselfishly in service to their fellow human beings without prejudice.

2. Recognition of Personal and Professional Limits: Members of the Chaplain Corps shall recognize that their skills are primarily those developed by clergy, and they should seek to use these skills with competence. They should recognize their limitations, both professional and personal, and take care not to extend themselves beyond the limits of their competence. They shall freely seek consultation with those who possess other skills, and freely make referral when such referral is in the best interest of the person they are called upon to help.

3. Personal Ethics: Members of the Chaplains Corps shall conduct themselves in a way consistent with the ethics required of their profession. They shall obey all laws. Should conscience compel a Chaplain to undertake acts of responsible civil disobedience, that Chaplain is expected first to consult the Lead Chaplain and the Sheriff, and if appropriate, willingly remove himself or herself from active duty as a Chaplain during the time of civil disobedience. Chaplains are highly visible to the community when driving a chaplain vehicle and must take great care to observe all traffic laws.

4. Remuneration: Members of the Chaplains Corps volunteer their services as servants to their fellow human beings. They shall accept no financial gift for services, nor perform any duties with the view of personal material gain.

5. Confidentiality: Members of the Chaplains Corps shall hold to the "Seal of Confession" without exception. They should not surrender to subpoena, testify in a court of law, or consult with anyone, professional or other, if to do

so would in any way jeopardize the "Seal of Confession", even at the risk of personal or professional harm. Privileged communication shall be regarded as highly confidential material and shall only be revealed when it is assumed that the greater good for the individual can be achieved by such revelation.

6. Consultation: Members of the Chaplains Corps should feel an obligation to refer individuals they come in contact with through their Chaplaincy role to the individual's own Minister, Priest, Rabbi, or other religious leaders for further counseling, if needed. If the individual is unaffiliated with any religious institution, the Chaplain still has an obligation to refer him or her to a clergy person of his or her faith. Exercising good and sound judgment, Chaplains should also feel an obligation to refer individuals in need to any other community agency that is established to address the individual's specific problems. At all times, the Chaplain must consider first and foremost the welfare of the individual he or she will be dealing with when making referrals.

7. Societal Obligations: Members of the Chaplain Corps have societal obligations. Except under the "Seal of Confession" and "Privileged Information", no knowledge of any criminal offense should be concealed. Chaplains who become aware of an individual who presents a risk to society should take action to provide the appropriate safeguards. In all cases, Chaplains are expected to employ sound judgment.

8. Proselytize: Members of the Chaplains Corps understand and accept the difference between imposing beliefs and revealing or sharing them. It is considered unethical to proselytize for allegiance within an established chaplain-counselee relationship. One's beliefs/faith can always be shared, but coercion is irresponsible.

9. Continuing Education: Members of the Chaplains Corps shall be committed to continued education in their professional discipline. They should engage regularly in experiences which are personally and professionally enriching.

10. Maintenance of the Code of Professional Ethics: The Lead Chaplain, in conjunction with the chaplains, shall be responsible for the continual upgrading and maintenance of this Code of Ethics.

11. Practices:

a) Members of the Chaplain Corps shall, when on duty, be clean and properly attired. Chaplains shall properly identify themselves, be courteous and always conduct themselves as a supporting aid of the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office. Chaplains shall wear their identification while they are in the Sheriff's Office Facilities.

b) Members of the Chaplains Corps are not Law Enforcement Officers and shall at no time assume such a role. The Chaplain's responsibility is to assist the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office when asked to do so in matters within the Chaplaincy realm. The Chaplain is reactionary; responding as a need is expressed. Chaplains shall not in any way interfere with the Deputy in the performance of the Deputy's duties. This also means that the Chaplain shall not respond to an incident without first being requested.

c) Members of the Chaplain Corps shall not publicly criticize the actions of any law enforcement officer or chaplain. Chaplains are not to gossip about other chaplains, or law enforcement officers, whether the subject is true or false. Any chaplain having a grievance shall bring it to the Lead Chaplain, or the Assistant Professional Standards Commander/CALEA Accreditation Manager, who shall in turn bring it to the Sheriff for review.

d) Members of the Chaplain corps shall keep themselves informed of all policies and procedure made available by the Lead Chaplain.